

Career success tips

Next Time You're Stressed at Work, Try This Tactic

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The worst part about feeling overwhelmed at work is that it's often a vicious cycle: Getting stressed out can affect your ability to work and even your **decision-making** — which only leads to more stress!

Many workers tend to deal with these feelings by attempting to rationalize them away or denying they exist. According to psychologist and executive coach **Erin Shrimpton**, however, this approach rarely if ever works. “The truth is, we can’t think ourselves out of overwhelm,” she says.

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taking some time to lower your stress levels, you can reclaim control of your day.

In her course on [Tips to Reset on an Overwhelming Day](#), Shrimpton shares tips on how to take a crucial step back whenever you're feeling consumed by stress. Next time you feel overwhelmed at work, follow this six-step process to get back on track.

How to be less stressed at work: 6 steps to reset and reevaluate

Step 1: Take a moment to stop thinking and breathe

Before you do anything else, take a moment to deal with the physical effects of stress. You might be clenching your jaw, tensing your muscles, and breathing hard without even realizing it. Stop what you're doing, close your eyes, and breathe deeply and slowly. You'll be amazed what a difference this can make.

"I like the 4-7-8 yoga technique," Shrimpton says. "You breathe in through your nose for the count of four, hold for seven, and breathe out through your mouth for eight."

Step 2: Address the source of your discomfort

Calmly evaluate the situation. "Tune into what's going on for you," Shrimpton says. "Be here now and ask yourself, 'Am I feeling discomfort? Where am I feeling it? And why?'"

As Shrimpton notes, the goal in this step isn't to "remove" the unpleasant feeling you're experiencing. "In fact, we want to learn to welcome it and observe what it is telling you," she says. In essence, the goal is to identify the source of your stress without judgement or emotion.

After you identify the source of your stress, you'll probably notice that you've also attached a lot of feelings to it. This step is about uncoupling yourself from those feelings.

"Take a moment to notice what you're telling yourself about the day's events so far," Shrimpton says. "Maybe you had an interaction that went wrong. Defuse from these thoughts."

Start by reminding yourself that your thoughts and feelings are just that: thoughts and feelings. For example, if you're thinking, "I'm frustrated that my presentation didn't land well at our meeting," remind yourself that what you mean is, "I'm having *the thought* that my presentation didn't go well at our meeting."

This simple but important distinction can help you realize that part of your stress is the story you're telling yourself about it. You may have even started to **catastrophize**, or jump to the worst possible conclusion about what happened.

Neuroscientist **Judson Brewer** addresses the value of separating from one's thoughts during challenging moments in his course, **Train Your Brain to Unwind Stress and Anxiety Habits**. Gaining awareness over our thought processes — and trying to understand why they're happening — is called "metacognition."

"We aren't our thoughts," Judson says. "By observing them as thoughts, we open the space to work with our thoughts instead of automatically believing them and habitually reacting to them. Sometimes all we need is a little distance from our thoughts."

Shrimpton echoes this sentiment: "Remind yourself that these thoughts don't control you," she says. "The narrative you're telling yourself about your day may not necessarily be true, and it doesn't have to be something you act on."

Prepare yourself to get back into action by asking a simple question: *What is important here?* Shrimpton recommends breaking down the answer into outcomes for you and the people affected.

After you settle on the desired outcome, consider how your most important values can help you get there. For example, if you value collaboration your next step could be brainstorming solutions with your colleagues.

“All of this allows you to deprioritize any unhelpful demands you’ve placed on yourself and to focus on the main issue at hand,” Shrimpton says. “This practice is transformative in making better decisions because it allows you to home in on and take action in line with what matters.”

Step 5: Reflect on what you need

Shrimpton stresses that this step is *not* about asking, “What do I need to do next?” Instead, it’s about asking, “What do I need?”

The best way to find the answer may strike you as ironic: Shrimpton recommends “doing nothing.”

“The brain is made up of lots of networks,” she explains. “One of those networks is called the default-mode network, and it’s active when we’re not particularly engaged in any goal-directed task. This is exactly why you always come up with your best ideas when you’re in the shower.”

So at this stage, let your mind wander. Go for a walk, get a cup of coffee, or just take a minute to stretch out and decompress. Let your thoughts come and go without judgement. Chances are, your mind will come up with some creative next steps for you.

Step 6: Reframe your ‘shoulds’ as ‘coulds’

possibilities and alternatives you could choose to explore — or not.

“It’s so easy to fall into the trap of thinking we should do things a certain way just because that’s how it’s always been,” Shrimpton says, “but have a look around: where’s the law that tells you it has to be that way?”

Resetting by following these steps will give you a whole new perspective on your situation. Instead of feeling backed into a corner by your stress, you’ll be able to see the possibilities and choose the right path forward. And the next time you feel stressed, you can always repeat this process to get here again.

*Looking for more tips on how to deal with overwhelm at work? Check out **[Managing Your Emotional Response to Workplace Stress](#)** for more ideas and pointers.*

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